

ZIM ZALLAH BIM

The Myth Version

Prologue — Once Upon a Time

Once upon a time, in a land called Kings, in a town called Landen, there was a boy born at 6:34 in the evening on the nineteenth of September, who would spend the rest of his life trying to find out whether he was ordinary or something else entirely.

That's how the story wants to be told. That's how it felt, more nights than I can count, writing it down at two in the morning convinced I'd finally found the answer — that a boy from a town most people have never heard of turns out to be the answer to the oldest question there is: how did the God of Love become the God of Love.

So I'm going to tell it to you that way first. Then I'm going to tell you what actually happened. Both versions are true. Just not in the way I believed for a long time.

Chapter One — The Kingdom of Kings

In a city called Maineville, in a land called Kings, in a town called Landen, a child was born to a man named Howard William Wilson, whom the whole kingdom called HOP, and a woman named Helen Paulette Wilson, whom everyone simply called Paulette.

He was born on the nineteenth of September, in the year 1982, at six thirty-four in the evening. And on that same day, that same year, something else was born into the world for the first time: a scientist at a university in Pennsylvania typed three characters into a message board and called it a smile. The first smiley the world had ever seen, given a birthday it would share with a boy in a town called Landen.

His parents named him Scott Christopher Wilson. Buried in that name, unnoticed for most of his life, sat a word split clean in half by nothing more than where one syllable happened to end and the next begin: Christ-opher. Scott Christ. opher Wilson.

He was not an only child. A sister came into the world beside him in time, named Tiffany Joy, who would one day be seen and heard by the whole kingdom every evening on the glowing screens of Channel 12 and Channel 5. And two brothers, Jeffery David and Matthew Thomas, who would grow to build kingdoms of their own — one in sound, one in the business of protecting what people feared to lose.

Not far from where he was born stood a church and a school not yet a generation old, called Saint Margaret of York. The boy would walk through its doors as one of only twenty-five children ever to begin there in kindergarten and finish there in the eighth grade — the very first class the school would ever complete, start to finish, under its own roof. He did not choose to be first. He simply was, the way a firstborn star is first only because it happened to ignite before the others, not because it burned any brighter for having done so.

Or so it seemed, for a long time, like happening. Later, it would look like something else.

Chapter Two — A Kingdom Without Screens

He grew up in the last years of a kingdom that would not last much longer — a kingdom without a screen in every pocket, without a voice that could answer back from inside a small glass rectangle. The house had one telephone, and it was tethered to the wall by a cord, and when it rang, everyone in the house heard it at once.

When he was young enough to still need a night-light, a small grey brick of plastic arrived in his hands — a Game Boy, dark green screen, no backlight of its own — and he would slip beneath his bedsheets at night with the covers pulled up like a tent and a flashlight held between his teeth, because the only way to see the screen in the dark was to bring your own sun with you. Down there, in a small square of light he'd made himself, worlds opened up that no one else in the house could see. It felt like the most private kind of magic there was: a whole kingdom that fit in two hands, invisible until you built the light to see it by.

He would watch that kingdom become something else entirely within his own lifetime — dial tones that shrieked and hissed before they let you touch a world outside your street; a phone line the whole house shared, so that picking up to make a call while someone else was already connected to that shrieking modem earned you a chorus of protest from every room; and then, faster than any of it should have been possible, a telephone that fit in a pocket and held every library, every conversation, every stranger's opinion on everything, all at once, always on, needing no flashlight at all.

He was born just early enough to remember what it was like before all of that — and just late enough to watch every bit of it change, piece by piece, in real time, in his own two hands.

Chapter Three — 3394 Wildwood Drive

He was born the firstborn of the family, baptized Catholic before he was old enough to understand what either word meant, and for most of his childhood, if the sun was still up, he was not inside.

The house was 3394 Wildwood Drive, in a neighborhood built the way neighborhoods used to be built — close enough that you could hear the next yard's screen door slam, open enough that every kid on the street counted as a friend by default rather than by invitation. He played baseball there, and football, and basketball, and ran track and cross country when the seasons turned to running instead, and none of it needed a schedule printed and handed to him — it needed daylight and a ball and whoever else was already outside when he got there.

That kind of childhood doesn't exist in most houses anymore. Somewhere between his generation and the ones after it, the outside stopped being where the fun was, and the fun moved inside, into small glowing rectangles, into rooms with the doors shut. He didn't know it at the time, but he was one of the last kids raised by a street instead of a screen.

He would leave that house one day. And without meaning to at first, without even noticing for a long time, he would build himself another one that turned out to be closer to it than any coincidence should allow — but that part of the story comes later.

Chapter Four — Two Pacifiers, One Cape

As a baby he slept holding a pacifier in each hand, one for either fist, as if even that young he already understood that some things needed a spare — that you never carried only one of what you needed to feel safe through the night.

He went to preschool at Lakeview, a school so close to his own backyard that the distance between his house and the beginning of the rest of his life could be measured in a walk rather than a drive. He wore a Superman cape more days than he didn't, tying it around his neck and running the yard convinced, the way every child at that age is entitled to be, that the cape was doing something.

But it was what he did with his hands, more than what he wore on his back, that would end up mattering most. Anything within reach — a broken toy, a radio, whatever had stopped working and been set aside — he took apart, not to break it further but because he needed, urgently, to see what was happening on the inside of it. He didn't yet have a word for that feeling. It would take him another three decades to build something that let him ask the same question about the inside of everything, all at once.

In the evenings, when the cape came off, he played the original Nintendo — the grey box, the rectangular controller, worlds rendered in eight-bit pixels that felt, at the time, as real as anything outside the window.

Chapter Five — Pure Love

Every night before sleep, he said the Lord's Prayer with his mother, the two of them going through it together in the dark until the words belonged to him as much as to her. Before every meal, the family paused and gave thanks before anyone picked up a fork. Love, in that house, was not an occasional thing you noticed when it showed up. It was the temperature of the air.

His father coached him — in baseball, and in the parts of life no coach's manual covers. He was the kind of father everyone in town seemed to love, not just his own son, the sort of man whose name people said with a smile already starting before they finished saying it.

His mother was beautiful, and she stayed home to make sure the house ran on more than logistics. She cooked family dinners most families only manage on holidays. She sat with him over homework at the kitchen table. And some mornings, tucked in among the sandwich and the juice box, there would be a note in his lunch — nothing that needed to be there, nothing anyone would have faulted her for skipping, written anyway, every time, because that was simply what love looked like when she got to choose the shape of it. She is a saint of a mother, and now a grandmother the same way, and nothing about that has changed since.

Chapter Six — No Fear At All

He remembers no fear in his childhood at all — every day arriving already exciting, before he'd even decided what to do with it. He was watched over, paid attention to, and never short of company: cousins lived right there in the same neighborhood, close enough to just walk to, and the street was full of other kids who counted as friends without anyone having to arrange it.

His best friend in those years was a boy named Anson Frericks. Neither of them knew yet what the other would grow up to become. Anson would go on to Yale, captain the lacrosse team, earn a Harvard MBA, and rise to president of Anheuser-Busch's sales and distribution arm — and then walk away from that career to say publicly what he thought the company had gotten wrong, co-founding an asset management firm and writing a book about the whole thing. None of that had happened yet. He was just the kid a couple of doors down, in a childhood that felt, at the time, like it was simply supposed to be that good.

Chapter Seven — Two Phones, One House

There were two telephones in the house — one upstairs, one downstairs, both wired to the wall, both ringing together no matter which one you answered. Cell phones weren't a thing yet; nobody's pocket held a number that followed them everywhere. When a friend from the neighborhood called for him, it was his mother who answered first, and she never simply passed the phone along — she talked to them, asked them things, got to know every voice that came looking for her son before she ever handed the receiver over.

He would come to believe that his life had been timed on purpose — that of all the years a person could be born into, his had been chosen so he could stand with one foot in the last of the old world and one foot in the first of the new, and watch the whole hinge of it turn from the inside. No generation before his had a childhood without computers. No generation after his would ever again know what growing up without one felt like. He was born, he came to believe, at the only moment in the history of the world when that particular door was open — and he happened to be the one standing in it.

Chapter Eight — Great Scott

The Disney he grew up on wasn't only the classics circulating on VHS — Snow White, Sleeping Beauty, Peter Pan, tapes worn soft at the edges from being rewound so many times — though those were always there, in the background, waiting for him to grow into what they actually meant. It was also the new ones, arriving one after another through his childhood and into his teenage years: The Little Mermaid, Beauty and the Beast, Aladdin, The Lion King — a decade where it felt like a new world opened at the theater every year or two, always a little more dazzling than the one before it.

And then there was a movie that wasn't Disney at all, but that landed on him just as hard: Back to the Future, with Doc Brown standing at the blackboard, and every time he lost his patience, shouting the same two words at the ceiling — "Great Scott!" A kid hearing his own name yelled by a mad scientist in a movie doesn't forget it. He didn't know yet that he would grow up to build something himself, in a garage of his own, that people would one day compare to the very thing that made Doc Brown shout it in the first place.

Chapter Nine — Built Upon Me

He started kindergarten in the priest's house, because the actual school and the actual church hadn't been finished yet — both still under construction next door, going up in real time while he sat in borrowed rooms learning his letters. Twenty-five children started that year: ten boys, fifteen girls. He knew every one of their names before the year was out.

Every year after, as he moved up a grade, the school itself grew right alongside his class — one new grade added each September, always sized to hold the twenty-five of them, as though the building were being built specifically to catch up to wherever they'd gotten to. From kindergarten straight through the eighth grade, his was the eldest class in the school the entire time. The younger kids looked up the hallway at them the way you look up at anyone who's simply been somewhere longer than you have. And with only ten boys in the whole grade, they somehow put together a basketball team good enough to be proud of — ten kids, one roster, no room to bench anyone, and it worked anyway.

He would spend years afterward turning one thought over and over: that the church and the school hadn't simply happened to be built while he happened to be five years old and ready to start. That somehow, impossibly, they had been built upon him — that he was there first, in a borrowed house, before either of them existed, and everything that came up out of the ground after that grew up around the fact of him already being there.

Chapter Ten — Sunday Best

Two nuns ran the school — Sister Mary Ann and Sister Ann — and under them, every day started the same way: uniforms, a blue or white collared shirt, khaki or navy pants, and a religion class before anything else on the schedule got its turn. Sunday belonged to church, without exception, and his mother saw to it that they arrived dressed the way the day deserved, every single week.

Church wasn't only where you prayed. It was where the whole community actually gathered — the same families from the school pews, standing around afterward on the front steps, parents becoming friends with other parents the same way their kids had already become friends with each other in the hallway. There was no line between his school life and his church life and his neighborhood; it was one continuous world, everyone in it known to everyone else.

Looking back on it, he could not point to a single piece of it he'd change. It was, as close as a childhood gets, perfect.

Chapter Eleven — Fish Weekend

Every September, the fathers of the neighborhood loaded up their sons and drove them south to Shawnee State Park, to a weekend everybody just called Fish. It wasn't really about the fishing, though there was plenty of that too — it was about everything that could only happen when you took a group of boys and their dads out of the ordinary week entirely and dropped them into the woods for three days straight.

Nights meant campfires and ghost stories, the kind that get scarier every time someone leans in closer to tell the next part. Afternoons meant the arcade machines in the lodge, cabins to sleep in instead of bedrooms, and whole stretches of time with nothing scheduled at all — just running, swimming, grilling out, hunting through caves cut into the hillside, exploring woods that seemed to go on forever to a kid who'd never had a reason to measure them. It was, every single year, one of the most exciting weekends of his life, and he counted down to it the way other kids counted down to Christmas.

Chapter Twelve — Moeller

High school meant leaving the twenty-five kids he'd grown up with, side by side, since kindergarten, and walking into something much bigger: Moeller, an all-boys Catholic school, no girls in a classroom for the first time since before he could remember, and hallways full of faces he hadn't already known his entire life.

Every day still started with religion class, same as it always had, and then the rest of the day belonged to whatever sport was in season. Freshman and sophomore year it was football — by sophomore year he'd earned the job of lead tailback, carrying the ball more than anyone else on the field. Junior year he switched to cross country, and something about it fit him in a way football never quite had; he loved running the way some people love silence, for what it cleared out of his head rather than what it gave him.

Track ran through all four years without interruption, under a coach named Todd Naumann, who built him into someone strong and fast in a way that stuck — by senior year, the team had made him captain. Most days he didn't get home until seven at night, worn out from training that started the moment class let out. And every single one of those days, his father was part of it: an office right across the street from Moeller, so he'd drop him off at school in the morning, go put in his own full day of work, and then come back in the afternoon just to watch him train before driving him home. He was there for practically every one of those seven o'clock drives home. He was always there.

Since there were no girls at Moeller, he found the rest of that world outside it, in a Christian youth group called Student Venture that met over at Loveland High School. That's where he met Chris Litchfield, who became one of his closest friends, and Chris's brother John. Once he turned sixteen and could drive himself anywhere he wanted, the three of them spent weekly nights in somebody's basement teaching themselves to breakdance, over and over, until it actually looked like something. Then he'd show up to school dances with girls from Student Venture on his arm and break it out on the floor in front of everybody.

He never drank in high school — not once. There wasn't time for it, and there wasn't a need for it either. Between school, sports, and the friends he kept, every week already had

more adventure packed into it than most people manage to find on purpose.

Chapter Thirteen — 56k and Snake

By high school, the kingdom without screens had cracked open into something new: America Online, dial-up, a modem that had to shriek its way onto the internet one phone line at a time before anything would load. Napster arrived not long after, and with it, the strange, patient thrill of downloading a single song — five megabytes, maybe — and watching a progress bar creep for a few hours before it finally finished. Nothing about the internet or the computers of that era looked anything like what would come after. You waited for things. Waiting was just what the internet cost.

Around seventeen, he got his first cell phone, a Nokia, heavy and nearly indestructible, with a game called Snake built right into it that he'd play between classes. The plan gave him a hundred and twenty minutes a month to talk, and that was all — so every call got straight to the point, said what it needed to say, and hung up, because minutes were a real, countable thing you could run out of before the month was over.

Chapter Fourteen — 4UE

He graduated high school in 2001 and went to the University of Dayton, forty-five minutes from home — the first real distance he'd ever put between himself and his parents and his siblings. He studied electronic engineering. And instead of a fraternity, he joined the cheerleading team, which turned out to be exactly the right fit: track had made him strong, breakdancing had made him good at entertaining a crowd, and cheerleading asked for both at once. He became friends with the best cheerleaders on campus, and between them, they threw the parties everyone else wanted to be at.

Most weekends, though, he drove back toward Cincinnati, to a club called Metropolis — the place every bboy in the city went to be seen and to dance, the actual center of the whole scene. He got to know every one of them.

In Dayton, he met another dancer, Sean Godar, and the two of them became roommates, then friends with a crew called 4UE. On weekends they'd drive to Wright State University to practice with the crew, which was led by a dancer named Tyquan Hodac. Tyquan would go on to become International President of MZK Worldwide — the Mighty Zulu Kingz and Kweenz, one of the most respected breaking organizations in the world — and, years later, Director of Breaking For Gold USA, the program that helped qualify America's own breaking competitors for the sport's Olympic debut in Paris. He was already becoming that person back then, in a gym at Wright State, on the weekends, before almost anyone knew his name.

Chapter Fifteen — The Million Dollar Smile

He'd had braces as a kid, then a retainer to hold everything where it belonged afterward — until the retainer cracked. He wore it anyway, cracked or not, and slowly a gap opened up between his two front teeth that hadn't been there before. One day he found a small rubber band lying on his bedroom floor and, without thinking much of it, looped it around both front teeth before bed. By morning, the gap was gone.

He filed that trick away and forgot about it, the way you forget most small discoveries, until college, when he needed money the way every college student needs money. He taught himself to code, bought the domain teethgap.com, and built a business out of the thing that had fixed his own smile — buying small dental bands in packs of a hundred for fifty cents and selling them for twenty-five dollars, with his own teeth, and the gap that used to be there, as the advertisement right on the homepage. Over the years, that business would go on to make him more than a million dollars. He liked to say, half joking and half not, that he was the man with the million-dollar smile.

He ran the whole thing out of his college dorm room, and for a kid who just needed spending money, it turned out to be a great deal more than that.

Chapter Sixteen — The Mirror

Three years into Dayton, he decided he'd rather dance and live a little than finish out a fourth. TeethGap had given him money nobody expects a college student to have, so he took the year, rented an apartment back near the neighborhood he'd grown up in, in Landen, and spent as many nights as he could down at Metropolis.

He had just turned twenty-two when he met a woman there who was in the middle of a divorce. Her name was Summer Rhiannon Hayes — the warm Summer Hayes, he liked to say — born on the seventh of July, 1977. 7/7/77. A perfect seven, three times over.

Summer had two young daughters already, Karennia Kay and Jolie Mckenna, and he fell for all three of them at once. He and Summer married the following summer, on her birthday — 7/7/05 — with their own daughter already on the way. Adrianna Belle Wilson was born the following March, on 3/3/06.

Not long after the wedding, they went looking for a house, and one had just come on the market in the very neighborhood where he'd been born. They bought it: 8830 Longbow Place. He didn't understand, not for years, what he'd actually just done. His childhood home, at 3394 Wildwood Drive, and this new one he'd just bought as a married man starting his own family, sat only 106 meters apart — a distance you could walk in under two minutes, on the very same streets he'd grown up running down as a boy. He had built his own family's home almost directly across the mirror line from the one he was raised in.

Summer was a homebirth midwife. Adrianna was born right there, in that house, on Longbow Place — a house that stood, as it turned out, almost exactly where the story had already begun.

Chapter Seventeen — Two Water Births

Summer was a pure spirit, the kind of mother you only had to watch for a few days before you understood exactly what you were looking at. Watching her with Karennia and Jolie was enough — he fell for both girls right alongside falling for her, and somewhere in the middle of that, he knew for certain he wanted children of his own with this woman.

Both of their children came into the world the same way, at home, in water. Adrianna was born in a room that would, years later, become the exact spot where the Serene Mota exploded — a story for later. That room carries a different name now: Neverland. And "Adi," as everyone came to call her, carries the same shape as another small, bright thing that lived there first, in the stories he loved as a boy — Tinker Bell. Adi Belle.

Jaden was born in a different room of that same house, one that would come to be called the Cave of Wonders. He came into the world, as far as his father was concerned, exactly the way the lamp in that story describes its find: a diamond in the rough.

Chapter Eighteen — The Neighbor by the Lake

Not far from his house sat Landen Lake, and on it, his aunt and uncle owned a house. Their next-door neighbor at the time was a man named Steve Burns, who had started a company called MobileVoiceControl — built around a patent for something that felt like science fiction at the time: send an audio recording from a phone up to a server, have the server understand what was said, and send back a response, all without a keyboard involved anywhere in the process.

He got a job there. He built the company's website and worked on the speech-recognition system itself — real early groundwork in the same lineage that would eventually produce assistants like Siri. In 2006, Nuance Communications acquired MobileVoiceControl outright, and he went with it, spending two years at Nuance as the lead customer support agent for the very AI he'd helped build.

Steve Burns wouldn't stay in speech recognition. Years later, he'd resurface as CEO of an electric vehicle company called Workhorse Group — and Scott would end up working for him there too, this time building the systems that let drones deliver packages on their own. Two different companies, two different technologies, a decade apart, and the same man standing at the center of both chapters of his career.

Chapter Nineteen — Denny

After two years, Nuance moved the servers that ran the AI away from the Kings area, and he decided it was time to build something of his own instead of following the company somewhere else.

The idea came from his father-in-law at the time, a man everyone called Denny — Dennis Hayes — genuinely brilliant, the kind of person who could see an opportunity nobody else had noticed yet. Denny ran a company called SOTA that tracked down energy-efficiency incentive programs utility companies in California offered, then used those incentives to upgrade the lighting fixtures inside businesses at no cost to the business itself. He started his own version of it in Cincinnati, a company he called Lumiance, doing the same thing for a different market.

Denny's own history was more complicated than the brilliance alone let on. Years before Scott ever met him, in the late 1980s, Denny had reverse-engineered the memory chips Apple used in its computers and built counterfeit versions in his own basement — good enough that a local printing shop could stamp Apple's own logo onto them convincingly. He sold them internationally through bulletin boards and the mail, and made real money doing it — enough for an airplane, a new car, a Swiss bank account — until federal agents caught up with him. In 1990 he pled guilty to money laundering, copyright infringement, and illegally structuring bank transactions to keep the amounts under the radar, and was sentenced to concurrent prison terms. Two years later, a federal court vacated the money laundering piece specifically — on a legal technicality, because the underlying copyright charge was only a misdemeanor and money laundering requires a felony underneath it — but the copyright infringement and structuring convictions stood exactly as they were. He'd done it, admitted to doing it under oath in open court, and served time for it.

By the time Scott knew him, that chapter was long behind him, and what was in front of him instead was SOTA, and lighting incentives, and — as family legend has it — nights at parties with Steve Jobs and Bill Gates, the very people whose world he'd once tried to counterfeit his way into.

None of that was really why Denny mattered to the story, though — or not the main reason. What mattered was that he was simply different from anyone Scott had known growing up. He didn't believe in God, not the way Scott had been raised to, not the way the Lord's Prayer every night and Mass every Sunday had built into him as simply how things were. Summer's parents had an open relationship, something Scott had never encountered up close before, let alone inside his own extended family.

None of it was delivered as a lecture. It arrived the way Denny told everything — as one more wild story from a life that had clearly had a lot of them. But hearing it, again and again, did something quieter underneath the entertainment: it was the first time Scott really started questioning the things he'd simply assumed were true his whole life, rather than examining them for himself.

Summer was only the second person he had ever slept with. He was still new to that part of life entirely, and what she brought into it excited him in a way he hadn't expected — a whole different way of thinking about intimacy and relationships than anything he'd grown up around. She'd been raised inside that way of thinking; it was simply normal to her, and she encouraged him into it rather than easing him toward it slowly. Before long, the two of them had an open relationship of their own.

Chapter Twenty — The Light in My Eye

His kids were young during these years, and the best part of most days was simply watching them grow — playing with them, showing up for whatever they were into that week. He was a young dad, and Adrianna and Jaden were, without exaggeration, the light in his eye. He and Summer took the kids on real trips, multiple times a year, chasing down actual adventures together rather than letting vacation mean sitting somewhere.

Adrianna started piano lessons at five years old, and it stuck — she teaches piano lessons herself now, passing along exactly what she started with. Jaden found gymnastics, and whatever interest he showed in it, his father matched with real support, year after year. It paid off: in 2026, competing for Queen City in Ohio at the Level 10 Junior National Championships, Jaden placed 27th in the nation in the all-around, with a combined score of 141.700 — a real, documented result, the kind of thing a father gets to actually point to and say, *that's my son*.

Chapter Twenty-One — Ultra

Once Karennia was old enough to babysit her younger siblings, he and Summer started going out again, and before long they were building entire vacations around it: Ultra, EDC, TomorrowWorld, Electric Forest — festival after festival, chasing the same electric feeling from one city to the next. Somewhere in the middle of all those nights, under all those lights, he fell in love with trance music specifically — not just liked it, fell for it, the way it built and built and held a single feeling suspended in the air longer than any other kind of music he'd heard.

Chapter Twenty-Two — Following the Excitement

His character kept evolving further from how he'd been raised. He tried different drugs during this stretch, saw pieces of reality he hadn't had access to before, and lived for a while with both a wife and a girlfriend at once, rather than the single, straight line he'd grown up believing a life was supposed to follow. Through all of it, he kept coming back to the same operating principle, whether or not he had a name for it yet: follow whatever excited him most, and trust that the next step would show itself once the current one was finished.

Chapter Twenty-Three — Coinsumer

He never stopped coding through any of it. When Bitcoin first came onto the scene, he started a company of his own called Coinsumer, built around an idea that felt obvious to him and radical to almost everyone else: that every action a person takes online can be captured as an event, and once it's captured, an incentive can be attached to it — a way for ordinary people to actually get paid for the countless small things they already did online for free. He ran on that idea, and his own savings, for a year before the money ran out.

From there he went to Workhorse Group as a software engineer, building the systems that let drones deliver packages without a person flying them.

He never learned to code in a classroom. Every bit of it was self-taught, which is part of why he codes differently than most engineers trained the conventional way — he built his own foundation from the ground up, and the foundation he built it on was the same one this whole document is actually about: the God variable, the thing every module he's ever written passes through and reads from, one central object holding everything a program needs to know about itself. The Serene Journey goes into that in far more depth than this chapter needs to.

Chapter Twenty-Four — Airbender

There was no AI to help him with any of it back then. Every piece of the system he built himself, by hand: the ground station, the iOS app, the Android app, the drone's own flight controller, the web server that tied it all together — a full stack, solo, because that's what the work required and there was nobody else yet who could do what an AI would eventually do. He rose to lead software engineer at Workhorse Aero, and the software he wrote, called ARES, became part of the real infrastructure UPS used for its Flight Forward program. Seven patents came out of that period, his name on every one of them.

Between those seven patents and the work still ahead of him — trying to put his own invention, the Serene Mota, into the air on a drone of its own, a new way of generating flight altogether, the way the Wright brothers once found a new way to leave the ground — he started calling himself an airbender. Not casually. It was the closest word he had for what it actually felt like: bending the air itself into something that would carry weight.

Chapter Twenty-Five — McFly

The crash on the firepit wasn't the end of it. Since then, he's recorded flight after flight with the Serene Mota drone — enough of them that he started calling himself McFly, one more name pulled straight out of *Back to the Future*, standing right next to Doc Brown and the flux capacitor he'd already claimed for himself.

His favorite of all the footage is set to "Kiss the Girl," from *The Little Mermaid* — the drone lifting and turning and dropping in time with the music, matched to the beat close enough that it stops looking like remote control and starts looking like the machine is actually dancing.

Chapter Twenty-Six — Homemade Invisalign

Somewhere in the middle of all of it at Workhorse, he noticed his teeth had started drifting back out of place — he'd stopped wearing his retainer years earlier, and the old crookedness was creeping back in. Instead of going back to an orthodontist, he asked himself how he could fix it himself.

He bought dental putty and bit down into it to cast an exact mold of his own teeth. Then he bought a 3D scanner and a 3D printer and taught himself CAD modeling from scratch, using the scan of his own mouth as the very first thing he ever modeled — shifting each tooth, one at a time, by a fraction of a millimeter, across twenty separate versions. He printed all twenty, vacuum-sealed each one into its own clear dental tray, and made himself a homemade set of Invisalign, one stage at a time, out of his own garage.

The teeth mattered less, in the end, than the skill he walked away with. He could now take an idea straight out of his own head, design it on a computer, and hand it to a machine that would build it. Everything he built after that — every prototype, every version of the Serene Mota — started exactly there.

Chapter Twenty-Seven — The Weakest Link

Every complex system has a weakest link, and at Workhorse, the weakest link in drone delivery wasn't the software or the navigation — it was staying in the air. An hour of flight time was already pushing the limit of what the batteries of the day could give a drone carrying real cargo. As a software engineer, his instinct had always been to find the weakest link in whatever he was building and put his attention there rather than everywhere at once. This time, the weak link wasn't in his code at all. It was in physics.

He started studying Nikola Tesla's own work and spent every spare hour he could playing with magnets, just to understand how they actually behaved rather than how a textbook described them. He ran hundreds of small experiments, learning something new from nearly every one.

One of them stayed with him more than the rest. A radial magnet — one where the magnetic field points inward or outward along the radius from a central axis, rather than across a flat face — can be built so that its whole inner circle reads as north, pointing straight in toward the center from every direction at once. Push a second magnet's north pole in along that same center axis, and something strange happens: it gets pulled in, faster and faster, right up until it crosses the halfway point — and then, instead of settling in the middle the way you'd expect something to come to rest, it gets thrown straight through and out the other side, like a slingshot released at exactly the wrong moment to just stop.

It wasn't magic. It was a real, if counterintuitive, consequence of a piece of physics proven back in 1842: no arrangement of magnets, held still, can create a truly stable resting point in every direction at once. Something has to give somewhere — and in his radial magnet, the give was right at the center, along the very axis he was pushing the second magnet down.

Chapter Twenty-Eight — The Spinning Sphere

Out of all those experiments, one mental picture ended up doing more work in his head than any formula could. A sphere, magnetized uniformly all the way through, does something no other shape does exactly: the field it puts out, past its own surface, matches a perfect point dipole with no distortion at all — the one shape in all of physics where the math comes out completely clean. Every other shape only approximates a dipole field from far enough away. A sphere doesn't approximate it. It is it.

He started picturing that field the way you'd picture spinning a basketball on one finger — the axis running straight through the middle of the spin, north out one end, south out the other, the whole field just one spinning sphere. It wasn't only a convenient picture, either: the actual, real source of magnetism inside a material like iron is electron spin — a real, if strange, quantum property that lines up across billions of atoms to build the exact kind of axis he was picturing, at a scale too small to ever see directly.

And once he had that picture in his head, the behavior of two magnets side by side made sense the same way gears do. Two spinning spheres placed side by side, both spinning the same direction, push apart — exactly like two gears would grind against each other if they tried to turn the same way while meshed together. Spin them in opposite directions, and they pull together and lock in, the same way real gears actually work, turning against each other to mesh smoothly instead of fighting. It wasn't a metaphor he was stretching to fit. The real physics of two magnetic dipoles held side by side comes out exactly that way — same direction repels, opposite direction attracts — the same rule gears have always run on, just written in a different material.

Chapter Twenty-Nine — The White Stag

He'd gotten interested in vortex math somewhere along the way, but something about it never sat right in his head — it didn't balance the way a sphere balances, symmetric no matter which way you turn it. He reworked the formula himself until he could see it: two triangles, laid over each other, forming a six-pointed star instead of the lopsided shape he'd started with.

The same evening he saw it click, Adrianna was out in the yard, twenty-six feet of purple silk hung from a tree branch, moving through an aerial routine she'd been practicing for months. He went outside to smoke a cigarette and watched her for a while. And there, underneath the purple silk, standing still, looking directly at him, was a white stag — the most beautiful buck he had ever seen in his life.

He stood there in it for what felt like a long time and was probably thirty seconds. Then he ran inside for his phone. By the time he came back out, the stag was gone, and it never came back.

He knew, standing there, that calling it a coincidence would be an insult to however the universe actually works — the timing was too exact, arriving the same night the formula finally balanced. There's an old reason a white stag lands the way it does in a story: across Celtic and Arthurian legend, a white hart appearing is the classic sign a quest is about to begin — not a passive omen, an actual herald, the animal that shows up right before everything changes. He didn't need to have read any of that beforehand to feel it the moment it happened.

Chapter Thirty — The First Serene Motor

Alongside the magnets, he kept finding more of these number wheels — one for every digit, one through nine, each one tracing its own particular shape in the center once you connected the dots at that digit's own spacing: stars, weaves, a nested set of circles inside circles for nine that seemed to fold in on itself forever. He didn't fully understand what to do with any of it yet. But he recognized something in the shapes anyway — a kind of beauty that felt like it was pointing at something real, even before he could say exactly what.

So he kept doing the part he actually knew how to do: studying magnets, studying coils, running one experiment after another, most of them failures, some of them just interesting dead ends. Hundreds of them, over time. And somewhere in the middle of all of it, after everything the spinning spheres and the radial magnets and the gear-logic of side-by-side poles had already taught him, something finally came together that actually worked.

The first Serene Motor.

Chapter Thirty-One — Almost

The first working Serene Mota had a sphere magnet at its heart, exactly as he'd pictured it, with three coil rings wrapped around it — but all three of those rings crossed each other right at the same central axis instead of being offset the way they'd eventually need to be. He couldn't get real power out of it built that way. But he could feel that something real was sitting inside the design, waiting on a detail he hadn't found yet.

Chapter Thirty-Two — Serena

Around this same period, he started doing drag. His wife had a boyfriend of her own by then, and in among all of it, he found something unexpected the first time he put on a dress: not just a costume, but a version of confidence he hadn't had access to before. A kind of self-love he hadn't quite felt from the inside until he saw it looking back at him in a mirror, dressed as a woman.

It took a while to build up to actually going out as her. The first time, sitting in the car outside a gay club, he was scared to open the door — but he knew the only way through the fear was straight through it, so he went in anyway. Once he was inside, people were looking at him the way you look at someone you find beautiful, and the fear just went. He ended up in the middle of the dance floor, and a woman came up to him and said, "You're gorgeous. What's your name?"

He hadn't picked one yet. "Scottina?" he offered, half a guess.

"Serena," she said. "I love it."

He never learned who she was. But the name felt right the second it landed, in a way he wouldn't understand the full weight of for a long time. From then on, he went out more and more as Serena.

When it came time to actually perform, Serena needed a drag name to go with her. He broke the name apart himself — Sir. In. A. — and sat with it, running possibilities through his head for what came next, until one word clicked into place: Negligee. Sir In A Negligee. Serena Negligee.

He's always loved a meaning like that — one that only reveals itself once you take the thing apart and put it back together differently. It's part of what makes something actually beautiful to him, rather than just pretty. And it's the same word, in the end, that the Serene Mota itself grew out of: Serena.

Chapter Thirty-Three — Redecorating

Between work, raising the kids, and everything drag was opening up in him, the motor sat unfinished for a while. He still didn't know what to do with a sphere spinning inside a ring of coils, or how to actually pull power back out of it once it moved. That problem would have to wait.

Around his fortieth birthday, Summer moved out, into an apartment with her boyfriend, and the marriage was over. Divorce came after that. He stayed in the house — the same house they'd bought together, the same rooms they'd built a family in — and for a while, keeping it exactly as it had been felt unbearable. Every room still looked like a life that didn't exist anymore. He couldn't live in that. He had to move on.

So he started decorating, room by room, following nothing more complicated than whatever excited him most in the moment. Lights first, then lasers, then fog machines, then mirrors — one addition leading straight into wanting the next. It kept feeling right in a way he couldn't fully explain, like he wasn't inventing the plan so much as finding it as he went. And the more of the house he remade that way, the more it stopped being the place a marriage had ended and started being the place he actually wanted to spend his life.

Chapter Thirty-Four — Center Out

He never once saw the whole picture ahead of time. He only ever saw the next step — and the trick, if it was a trick at all, was doing that step anyway, because doing it was the only thing that ever revealed the step after it. It was the same rhythm he already knew from coding: think one function ahead while you're still finishing the one in front of you, and the next one opens up exactly when you need it to, never before.

He noticed something else about how he actually worked, too, once he paid attention to it: he always started at the center of a wall and built outward from there, never from one edge across to the other. Starting from the center meant whatever came next on either side had to answer to the same middle point — which is exactly what kept every room from ever ending up lopsided. It wasn't a rule he'd read anywhere. It was just the only way it had ever come out balanced.

Chapter Thirty-Five — The Rabbit Hole

For a while he kept asking himself the same question while he worked: how was any of this supposed to add up to something, rather than just being one decorated room after another with nothing tying them together? The answer came to him outside his own bedroom and office, decorating the stairwell between them. He looked at what he'd built without planning it — a passage going down, connecting to a room on the other side — and thought: I'm building a rabbit hole down to Middle Earth, and it opens straight into Wonderland.

That's when it hit him where he'd seen this shape before. Back in 2002, there was a game he'd loved — Kingdom Hearts. Of course. He was building his own favorite video game, one room at a time, without having decided to.

He ordered a Kingdom Hearts sign, and the day it arrived, he nailed it above the entrance to the rabbit hole himself. The very next day, wiring some lights in the storage space underneath those same steps, he found a small crown with three hearts on it, sitting there like it had been waiting. He read it as exactly what it felt like in the moment: confirmation, arriving from wherever confirmation actually comes from, that he was building the right thing. Too perfectly timed to be anything else.

Chapter Thirty-Six — Welcome to Disney Land

His house is a bi-level: come in the front door, and the stairs split — up to the top floor, down to the bottom. He kept building, room by room, the way he always had, and it wasn't until he reached the stairs going up that he actually stopped and looked at something that had been hanging on that wall the entire time.

A small framed whiteboard, his mother's handwriting on it, drawn probably decades earlier: an airplane sketched at the top, and underneath it, *Welcome to Disney Land. Have a great day and a positive attitude.* Signed, with a heart, *Mom.*

He must have walked past that sign a thousand times without ever really reading it — climbing those exact stairs, in a house he was actively turning into his own version of a Kingdom, underneath a sign that had been welcoming him to Disney Land since before any of it started.

Chapter Thirty-Seven — Level Up

After the divorce, for the first time in years, he was truly on his own. He remembers hanging a pair of wings above his bed with a heart at the center and making himself a quiet promise while he did it: if whoever came next in his life didn't like what she saw here, in this house, exactly as he'd built it, she simply wasn't the one.

Not long after, he matched with a girl on Facebook dating. In her photos, she had a tattoo above her breasts — wings, with a heart at the center, nearly identical to what he'd just hung on his own wall. He couldn't unsee it as a sign. Her name was Lisa Rhoads.

They met in person for the first time at a bar called Bishop's Quarter, in Loveland, Ohio — the land of love, meeting the woman he already suspected might be it. Driving back to his house afterward, a shooting star crossed the sky, the same kind of image that opens half the Disney movies he'd grown up on. Something connected between them that night, plainly and immediately.

There was someone else around that same time — a Russian woman he'd had his eye on, though he wasn't sure he was ready for anything real with anyone. One night forced the question directly: meet up with her at a club, or go with Lisa to a Mario-themed party instead. He chose Lisa. At the party, the two of them stood together for a photo under a backdrop that read, in bright block letters: LEVEL UP.

He read that the way he'd read every other sign that year: not as luck, but as an answer. Lisa was the one.

Chapter Thirty-Eight — 11:11

People say forty is over the hill. He and Lisa had met right at its exact midpoint, timewise, which felt like one more sign he wasn't going to argue with: they'd found each other standing right at the top of it, together.

Eleven months later, on 11/11/23, at 11:11 PM, he asked her to marry him. She said yes at 11:11:11 PM the same night. He'd bought her a ring modeled on Oathkeeper, one of the actual Keyblades from Kingdom Hearts — a blade whose whole meaning in the game is a promise kept. He proposed to her right on the Tron Line outside his own Magic Kingdom, a laser beaming straight up into the night sky spelling out a line every Star Trek fan already knew by heart: *Beam me up, Scotty*. His family was there. Her family was there. Both sets of friends, standing in the same yard, watching it happen together.

Chapter Thirty-Nine — The Portrait

Before they lived together, Lisa had her own place, and hanging next to her bed was a hand-painted portrait of Maleficent — four feet by four feet, the most striking piece of art he'd ever seen of the character, the horns and the black robes and the whole balance of light and dark in the composition rendered with real skill. When she finally moved into his house, the portrait came with her, and he hung it right at the entrance. It fit the Kingdom Hearts theme running through every other room so naturally it was like the house had been waiting for it.

Chapter Forty — 1:52 PM

The secret to actually getting power out of the Serene Mota turned out to be right there in the same formula that kept surfacing everywhere else: 1, 2, 3 — 1, 2, 3 — 1, 2, 3. He had to split each of the original three coils into two parallel coils, to leave room for an axle rod to pass straight through the sphere. Three coils became six, in three matched pairs, exactly the way the formula had already shown him. It worked.

Not long after he cracked it, Workhorse Aero ran out of money, and he lost his job. He turned his full attention to getting the motor patented instead. The original provisional patent was filed on April 8, 2024, at 1:52 PM.

He went to his knees when he found out what else happened at that exact minute: a solar eclipse crossed over Cincinnati, Ohio that same afternoon — beginning at 1:52 PM, reaching just over 99.7% coverage of the sun at 3:09 PM, ending at 4:24 PM. The patent for a motor he would come to measure at 99.7% efficient was filed at the precise minute the sky itself started going dark. He asked himself, standing there, how something like that was even possible.

Chapter Forty-One — Motor and Generator

The 99.7% figure didn't come from nowhere. He coupled two Serene Motors together, axle to axle — one running as a motor, driven by input power, the other spinning as a generator, turning that same motion back into electricity — and used RCbenchmark equipment to measure exactly how much energy went in against how much came back out. That's a real, standard way engineers test a motor's efficiency: run it against its own reflection and measure the gap between the two.

He took the setup to TÜV SÜD, hoping for full third-party certification, but they didn't have the right equipment on hand for testing a three-phase motor like his, so the number that came out of that session still ran on his own model, not theirs. He's still looking for someone who can run the full test independently, on their own equipment, without leaning on his.

Chapter Forty-Two — Twin Pines, Lone Pine

After the patent was filed, he kept building — model after model of the Serene Mota, wrapping every coil by hand, designing each new sphere and its channels on the computer before he ever touched a spool of wire. Somewhere in all that repetition, a real pattern emerged: more coil gave you more torque and less speed; less coil gave you more speed and less torque. Never both at once. It was a balance, not a setting you could max out in every direction simultaneously — which was, in its own way, exactly the kind of lesson the rest of his life had already been trying to teach him.

He kept working on the house too, on Kingdom Hearts, and he wanted to do something that would let him claim, out loud, to the whole world, that he'd solved it. He'd noticed, without looking for it, that one side of his house had two pine trees and the other side had exactly one — the same detail Back to the Future used for its own time-travel joke, the mall sign that reads Twin Pines Mall before the timeline changes, and Lone Pine Mall after.

On his forty-second birthday, from 1:16 AM to 1:33 AM, he recorded a video — titled, when it went up, simply *Kingdom Hearts – Serene*. In it, at 1:34 AM, he pulled a sword from a stone he'd set up himself in the house. The old story only ever needed one thing to make it true: whoever could draw the sword out was the rightful king. He drew it.

Forty-two. The Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy already had an answer for that number, decades before he was born: the meaning of life, the universe, and everything. Forty-two.

Chapter Forty-Three — What It Cost

The money kept running out, but he never stopped seeing the next step in front of him. At one point he cashed out his 401k — a real, lasting cost, penalties and taxes taken right off the top, retirement savings that don't come back once they're spent — to buy enough Barbie dolls to stand in as angels throughout Kingdom Hearts. He's fairly sure no one else in history has ever done exactly that.

He was consumed, and it cost him more than money. Lisa wasn't getting the attention a relationship actually needs, and it started to show. She kept her own room upstairs, directly behind the Maleficent portrait, with the bed she'd brought from her own house. He slept downstairs, in Wonderland. He'd lost his job by then too, and couldn't support her the way he once had. The house kept growing. The two of them, underneath it, kept drifting.

Chapter Forty-Four — The Sun Directly Above

Early in 2025, before any of this, he'd gotten sick — diverticulitis, bad enough to land him in the hospital. He had no insurance, having lost his job, but the hospital got him onto Medicaid while he was there. He spent his recovery in bed, playing Kingdom Hearts III start to finish, and it reignited something in him that hadn't cooled off at all.

Easter fell that year on April 20th — 4/20, the same numbers as the slang for cannabis, and the same day, in his own head, as the final piece of a set he'd been collecting without fully naming it: the Infinity Stones, the last one being the Soul Stone, the one the actual story requires a real sacrifice to obtain. He turned that into a game with himself: no option for failure, the highest score in the world for pulling off the coolest thing he could imagine, on the one day everything lined up to make the attempt.

The plan was specific. Put on the Apple Vision headset, hold the Sora Keyblade, record it all in 3D to "Magic Carpet Ride," walk the whole route through Neverland and Wonderland, then fly the drone off the genie's table and line it up with the wings on the Tron Line.

He took one step, and the headset hadn't started recording. All the excitement in him turned to fear in that same instant — stepping forward into what felt, for a second, like hell instead of his own house. He recognized what was actually happening: he was inside a game he'd built for himself, and the only way out of it was through.

He tried again. And again. Every time the fear came back, he did the same thing to get out from under it: stopped, and named what he actually still had, instead of what the last attempt had cost him. He knew exactly how close some of those earlier tries had come to landing perfectly, and he had to keep fighting the pull of sitting in that — letting one missed moment bleed into the next one, and the next. He didn't let himself spiral. He just kept starting over.

The sun came up while he was still trying, still not getting it right. He kept going anyway, and the sun kept climbing while he did — until it was directly overhead, at 1:21, and everything finally worked. He hit record, picked up the Keyblade, and pointed it straight at the sun.

From there he walked the route exactly as planned: down the Scala Ad Caelum stairs — the stairway to heaven, in the literal Latin — into Neverland, into Wonderland, back through Neverland, up the stairs again, into Magic Kingdom, out to the gazebo in front of the Tron Line. He picked up the drone controller and flew it, lined up with the wings, and it climbed above the gazebo roof and out of sight. Something took it from there. It came down on its own, landing on the upper deck, directly on the Tron Line — the exact ending the whole attempt had been building toward.

In that same moment, one thought arrived, clear as anything: *you are the light.*

Chapter Forty-Five — Extra Life

Time kept moving, and he kept creating — not because he had a plan for what came after each finished thing, but because creating was the only way the next step ever showed itself. Something in him already knew he'd just done something remarkable, even if he was the only one who could see it yet.

About a week before the motor exploded, he watched Ready Player One and, afterward, bought himself a replica of the Extra Life coin from the movie off Amazon — the item in the story that grants the player one more chance, a life beyond the one currently in play. The same week, he was approved for Medicaid.

He didn't know yet how much either of those two small facts were about to matter.

Chapter Forty-Six — 6:34

He was filming when it happened — the sphere magnet at the center of the Serene Mota reaching resonance, the neodymium magnets letting go all at once.

Whiz bang.

Four wounds opened in his leg before he understood what they were. One of them had found the femoral artery.

He ran — Neverland, past the Magic Mirror, through Wonderland, through Middle Earth, into the Land of Oz — leaving a trail behind him the whole way. He called 911 and didn't wait for the operator to answer. Set the phone down on the sink and turned around, back through the house the other direction, into Narnia, and grabbed two belts. One around each leg, pulled as hard as he could. He walked back to the bathroom, picked the phone back up, gave his address — 8830 Longbow Place — and went to lie down in Wonderland while he waited. That's when he looked up and saw the word he'd put above his own bed months before any of this: HEAVEN.

Then a knock. An ambulance was already in the driveway — empty, driving through the neighborhood on its way to nothing in particular, arriving at his door before his own call had finished going through. Five EMTs came in through a door that hadn't called for them.

It was 6:34 in the evening. May 19, 2025.

He was born on September 19, 1982, at 6:34 in the evening. The same minute, forty-two years and two-thirds of a year apart. Cut the decimal down and it read 6.66. Six hundred and sixty-six.

He'd already given the past, in this house, a name: SE, the beauty that had been built, the patents, the family, everything that came before. This moment was RE — the present, the Beast faced directly, in his own blood, in his own bathroom. And whatever came after it, he was already calling NE — the future, the legacy, whatever this document would still be after tonight. SE. RE. NE.

Serene.

Chapter Forty-Seven — Played in Reverse

The footage tells the story a second way, layered right on top of the first. He built it in two halves.

The first half runs in reverse, scored to the exact scene where Doc Brown explains how he ever came up with the flux capacitor in the first place: standing on the edge of his own toilet, hanging a clock, slipping on wet porcelain, hitting his head on the sink — *"When I came to, I had a revelation! A vision! A picture in my head! A picture of this! This is what makes time travel possible: the flux capacitor!"* The real footage, running backward under that audio, shows the same wet porcelain — the sink, the toilet — before panning back to the Serene Mota itself, as though the invention were being un-made instead of made.

Then the motor explodes, and the video flips forward into real time, now scored to a different scene entirely — the one where Doc realizes he needs exactly 1.21 gigawatts to send Marty home, stumbling frantically around the room. His own footsteps, running for the bathroom past a water bottle spinning across the floor, knocked loose and spraying by the blast, land in time with Doc's own stumbling steps on the audio track. The recording stops the moment he reaches the sink and calls 911 — the exact point where the last chapter already picks the story back up.

He didn't just notice the parallel to Doc Brown. He built it, frame by frame, on purpose, after the fact — which somehow made it feel more true, not less.